

Edinburgh Castle - Kids

UK Family Tour

The Most Attacked Castle in Britain

You're climbing onto the plug of an extinct volcano — the same one from this morning's walk — and on top of it sits the most besieged castle in Britain. Edinburgh Castle has been attacked at least twenty-six times in its history. Everybody wanted it, because whoever held this rock held Scotland's capital. The cliffs protect it on three sides; the only way in is the way you're walking, up the tail of the volcano — which is why every defense faces this direction. The sneakiest capture happened in 1314, during the Wars of Independence, when the castle was held by the English. A Scot named Thomas Randolph had a secret weapon: a soldier called William Francis who, years earlier, had lived in the castle and had secretly climbed down the "impossible" north cliffs at night to visit his girlfriend in town. He knew a hidden route up the rock face. So thirty men climbed the cliff in the dark, hauled up ladders, popped over the wall, and took the castle from the inside. All because of a young man sneaking out to see his girlfriend. As you cross the drawbridge, look for the statues of William Wallace and Robert the Bruce guarding the gate — Scotland's two greatest heroes, whose stories you'll hear more of at Stirling in two days.

Related listening: Castle Rock and Arthur's Seat are siblings, vents of the same ancient volcano field. Coming up — "You Are Climbing a Volcano" (Arthur's Seat, Day 12). Related listening: Scotland's two great fortress rocks, contested in the same wars. Coming up — "The Castle That Was the Key to Scotland" (Stirling Castle, Day 11).

Tell Me More: Sieges, Dogs and a Piper

More castle stories. The castle has its own soldiers' dog cemetery — a tiny garden on the ramparts where regiments buried their mascots and officers' dogs for a hundred and fifty years, with little headstones you can see from above. Soldiers take their dogs seriously here. The castle also has a legend about a lone piper: long ago, the story goes, a secret tunnel was discovered running from the castle down under the Royal Mile, and a piper boy was sent in to explore, playing his bagpipes as he went so those above could track his progress under the street. The music moved down the Mile... then stopped, somewhere around the Tron, and the boy was never seen again. People claim you can sometimes still hear faint piping under the street. (Take this one with a large pinch of salt — but it's a good one to retell at dinner.) Real history that sounds fake: during World War One, the castle vaults held prisoners of war, and one German prisoner made a daring escape by hiding in a cart — the vaults still have graffiti carved by prisoners, including a carving of a ship made by a French prisoner two hundred years ago, and there's even a record of prisoners forging fake money in here. And in World War Two, the Honours — the crown jewels you're about to see — were buried again, this time right here inside the castle, in case of Nazi invasion. Only a handful of people knew the exact spots. The crown spent the war under a medieval toilet closet. True.

The Volcano Under Your Feet

Let's go back in time, way, way back, further than knights and castles, further than the Romans, all the way to when this rock was born. About three hundred and forty million years ago, long before there

were dinosaurs, there was no castle here and no city, just a bubbling volcano. Deep underground, red-hot melted rock pushed up toward the surface through a crack in the earth. But here's the surprising part. This volcano never had a big dramatic eruption that you'd draw with orange lava pouring down the sides. Instead the molten rock got stuck in the volcano's throat, cooled down slowly, and turned rock-hard, like a plug jammed in the neck of a bottle. That plug is what you're standing on. It's some of the toughest, hardest rock in the whole region.

Now spin the clock forward, millions and millions of years, to the ice ages. Imagine a sheet of ice so thick it would bury this entire castle, taller than the tallest building you've ever seen, grinding very slowly across the whole of Scotland from west to east. That ice was like a giant sheet of sandpaper. It scraped away all the soft rock around here, wearing the land down flat. But when the ice reached this hard volcanic plug, it couldn't grind it away. The plug was too tough. So the ice split and flowed around it, and everything in the sheltered space behind the rock, tucked in its shadow, was protected.

That's why the shape of this whole hill is so strange, and so useful for a castle. On one side you have this steep cliff of hard old volcano, the "crag." And stretching away behind it, going gently downhill, is a long ramp of the softer rock that the ice couldn't quite reach, the "tail." Grown-ups call the whole shape a crag and tail. You already walked up the tail this morning, all the way up the Royal Mile. Think about that. A river of ice, thousands of years ago, decided exactly where Edinburgh's most famous street would go. The castle sits up on the crag with cliffs on three sides, and the town trails down the tail behind it. Fire made this rock. Then ice carved it into the perfect throne for a fortress.

The Tiny Oldest Building

Somewhere near the top of the castle there's a little stone building so small you might walk right past it. It only holds about twenty people squeezed in tight. But look closely, because this plain little box is the oldest building in the whole city of Edinburgh. It's called Saint Margaret's Chapel, and it has been standing here for almost nine hundred years, since around the year eleven thirty. That means it was already old when knights in armor were still a new idea. Every other building on this rock has been smashed and rebuilt, again and again, but this tiny chapel somehow survived it all.

Here's why it's still standing. Remember the sneaky night attack in thirteen fourteen, when Scottish soldiers climbed the cliffs and took the castle back from the English? Afterward, Robert the Bruce gave a harsh order. He said tear the castle down, knock over the walls, so the English can never use it against us again. His soldiers wrecked nearly everything. But when they came to this one small chapel, they stopped. It was a holy place, and even in the middle of a war, they left it alone. So while mighty towers and thick walls were flattened into rubble, the smallest, humblest building on the rock was spared, and that's exactly why it outlived them all.

The chapel is named after a queen. Her name was Margaret, and she lived even before the chapel was built. She was actually an English princess who fled north to Scotland long ago and married a Scottish king called Malcolm. People said she was extraordinarily kind, that she fed poor children with her own hands and gave away her money to anyone in need. After she died, the church declared her a saint. Her son, King David, built this little chapel high on the rock in her memory, so people could pray there and remember his mother. And here's a strange twist. Over the centuries everyone forgot what the building even was. For years soldiers used it as a storeroom for gunpowder, of all things, until someone finally realized this dusty little shed was a royal chapel nearly seven hundred years old. Step inside if you can. You're standing in the oldest room in Edinburgh.

The Prison in the Rock

Deep under the middle of the castle there are cold stone rooms with curved ceilings, and hundreds of years ago they were packed with prisoners. Not robbers or bandits, though. These were enemy soldiers and sailors, captured in wars far out at sea and brought here to be locked up in the dark heart of the rock. Imagine being a sailor from France, or Spain, or America, snatched off your ship, marched for days, and shut inside a cold cellar on top of a cliff in a country you've never seen, thousands of miles from home. That really happened to real people right beneath where you're standing.

So what do you do, stuck in a cellar with nothing but time? You get clever. These prisoners started making things, and they were amazing at it. With bits of bone, straw, and scraps of wood, they carved tiny ships, little boxes, dominoes, and whole chess sets, so small and so perfect it's hard to believe they were made in a dark prison by hand. And here's the best part. On most days, they were allowed to sell them. Ordinary people from the town would come up to a barrier, and the prisoners would sell their little treasures for a few coins, enough to buy some tobacco or a treat. Some of those tiny handmade ships still exist today. Enemies, locked in a dungeon, becoming toy-makers.

Now look for the old wooden prison doors, because the prisoners left secret messages scratched right into the wood. Names, drawings of ships, all sorts. But one carving is famous all over the world. An American prisoner, feeling homesick around the year seventeen eighty, carved a picture of the American flag, the Stars and Stripes, into a door. It might be one of the very oldest pictures of that flag anywhere outside America itself, scratched into a prison door by a lonely sailor who just wanted to go home.

And did anyone ever escape? Oh yes. One night in eighteen eleven, a group of French prisoners pulled off something daring. They secretly chipped a hole right through the wall, then tied their washing lines together into long ropes and climbed down the cliff in the dark, dozens of them slipping away into the night. Nearly all of them were caught again, and one poor fellow tumbled and broke his leg on the way down. But it gave the guards such a fright that soon afterward they decided a cellar in a cliff was no place to keep prisoners, and they closed the prison for good. Step into those vaults if you can, put your hand on the cold stone, and imagine the sailors carving their little ships in the gloom.

The Castle That Wouldn't Give Up

Here's a story about the longest, most stubborn fight this castle ever saw. It's called the Lang Siege, which is just the old Scottish way of saying the long siege, and it went on for about two whole years, from fifteen seventy-one to fifteen seventy-three. Think about that. Two years of being surrounded, with enemies camped all around the rock, and the people inside refusing to give up.

Why wouldn't they surrender? Because of loyalty to a queen. This was the time of Mary, Queen of Scots, and by now poor Mary was already a prisoner far away in England. Her cause looked completely lost. But one brave and stubborn soldier, a man named Sir William Kirkcaldy, decided he would hold this castle for her no matter what, long after almost everyone else had given up hope. For two years he and his men clung to the rock, running low on food, running low on water, but simply refusing to quit.

In the end, it wasn't swords or ladders that beat them. It was cannons. The Queen of England sent up heavy guns and expert gunners, and they blasted the castle without mercy. People think they fired something like three thousand cannonballs in just a few days, a storm of iron smashing into the walls. The main target was the castle's biggest, proudest tower, called David's Tower, a gigantic stone keep. Under all that pounding, the great tower cracked and finally came crashing down in a landslide of stone. And when it fell, it buried the castle's main well, so now the defenders had no water at all. That was the end. Sir William had to surrender, and it went very badly for him.

But now for the amazing part, the part you can actually go and find. When the huge tower collapsed, the broken bottom of it was left there, and instead of clearing it away, the winners just built a giant curved

wall of guns right on top of the rubble. That curved wall is called the Half Moon Battery, and it's the big rounded rampart you can see as you walk up toward the palace. So that famous shape is really a scar, healed right over a smashed tower.

And the bottom of David's Tower didn't disappear. It got sealed up inside that new wall and forgotten for more than three hundred years, until people rediscovered it in nineteen twelve. Today you can duck through a low doorway and climb down into those cold, dark, secret rooms, the very rooms that survived the great siege. Most visitors walk straight past the little entrance and never even know it's there. See if your grown-ups can help you find the way down into the buried tower.

The Volcano's Family

You already know the castle sits on an old volcano. But here's a secret. This volcano has family nearby, and you're going to visit one of its relatives later on this trip. Look out across the city toward the east, and you'll spot a big green hill with a rocky top rising up above all the buildings. That hill is called Arthur's Seat, and it's an old volcano too, a brother or a cousin of the very rock you're standing on right now.

They were born together, in the same burst of fiery activity, about three hundred and forty million years ago, back when this whole part of Scotland was sitting near the equator, hot and tropical, with the ground splitting open and rumbling. Arthur's Seat was the big volcano, and your castle rock was a smaller one right beside it, like a little vent puffing away next to a giant. So they really are family, made from the same underground fire, at the same faraway time, before there were any dinosaurs at all.

And then the very same thing happened to both of them. Remember the enormous sheet of ice that came grinding across Scotland and carved this rock into a cliff at the front and a long gentle ramp at the back? That exact same ice did the very same thing to Arthur's Seat. That's why, when you look at it, it has the same funny shape, a steep rocky cliff on one side and a long slope trailing away behind. Two volcanoes, sculpted by the same giant river of ice into the same lopsided shape. Once you know the trick, you'll spot it everywhere in Edinburgh.

Here's something to look forward to. In a few days you're going to climb Arthur's Seat, right up to the top. And when you do, you'll actually be standing on a real volcano, a sister to this castle rock, looking back across the whole city at the fortress where you're standing today. You'll be able to wave from one ancient volcano to the other. People sometimes say Arthur's Seat looks like a giant sleeping lion, curled up above the city, with its head at one end and its long body stretching away. See if you can see the lion from up here. It has been sleeping for millions of years, and it isn't going to wake up, so it's perfectly safe to climb right onto its back.

The Dog Soldiers' Graveyard

You might already know there's a tiny dog graveyard up here on the castle. Now let's meet some of the dogs, because every one of those little headstones belonged to a real dog with a real story, and soldiers loved them dearly. For soldiers, a dog wasn't just a pet. A dog could be the regiment's mascot, marching along with the soldiers, travelling the world with them, keeping everyone's spirits up when they were far from home and frightened. When one of these dogs died, the soldiers were heartbroken, and they gave their friend a proper little grave right here on the rock, with a carved stone, just like a person.

The graveyard started way back around the eighteen forties. The very first dog buried here, people say, was called Fido, the beloved dog of the officer in charge of the castle. After that, dog after dog was laid to rest in the little garden, until there were about twenty small headstones. If you peer down at them from above, you can still read some of the names.

There's Jess, a band pet of a famous Scottish regiment called the Black Watch, whose stone is one of the oldest you can still read. There's a brave bull terrier named Dobbler, who travelled with his regiment of Highlanders for nine whole years, going wherever the soldiers went, before he died and was buried here with honour. There's a dog called Pat, a mascot who was so loyal and so loved by his soldiers that when he died they gave him a hero's funeral. And one of the last dogs buried here was called Winkle, who died in nineteen eighty and belonged to the family in charge of the castle. So this little patch of earth holds nearly a hundred and fifty years of very good dogs.

Here's the thing to remember about this spot. All around you the castle is about kings, cannons, crowns, and battles, huge and important things. But the soldiers who lived here also made room, on the highest, most precious ground in the country, for their dogs. Big tough soldiers, who faced cannons and swords, cared so much about their four-legged friends that they buried them like heroes. Look down at the little stones and give the good dogs a quiet hello. They earned it.

BANG! The One O’Clock Gun

If it’s almost one o’clock, get ready — and maybe cover your ears. Every day except Sunday, a real artillery gun is fired from the castle walls at exactly 1 PM, and it has been happening since 1861. Tourists jump. Locals don’t even blink — spotting who flinches is how Edinburghers identify visitors. Why fire a gun at lunchtime? Same reason as the red ball you saw drop in Greenwich: time for ships. Sailors in the harbor of Leith needed an exact signal to set their clocks for navigation. Edinburgh built both — a time ball on a monument AND a gun, because on foggy days you can’t see a ball drop, but you can always hear a cannon. And why one o’clock instead of twelve, like other cities? The joke Edinburghers tell on themselves: firing one shot instead of twelve saves eleven cannonballs’ worth of gunpowder — classic Scottish thrift. There used to be an amazing detail: since sound travels slowly, a map was published showing how many seconds to add depending how far you lived from the castle. People across the sea in Fife added around fifteen seconds. Nearby, meet Mons Meg, a monster cannon from 1457 that could hurl a stone cannonball heavier than a grown man about three kilometers. Stick your head near the barrel — it’s half a meter wide.

Tell Me More: Gun Stories

Gun stories, collected. The One O’Clock Gun has had famous gunners — the longest-serving, “Tam the Gun,” fired it for over twenty-five years and became a city celebrity; the first female gunner took over in the two thousands. The gun has been fired by special guests, has appeared in countless movies of people jumping, and once, during a power cut, had to be fired using an old-fashioned backup method, because the one o’clock BANG simply cannot be late — Edinburghers set their watches by it and would notice. During the World Wars the gun fell silent (a cannon firing daily over a city at war sends the wrong message), and when it returned, crowds came to celebrate the BANG coming back. Now, Mons Meg: when she was young, in 1497, King James the Fourth dragged her to besiege an English castle — moving her took a hundred men and reportedly crushed roads as she went, at a top speed of about five kilometers a day. Slower than you walk. Her cannonballs were so huge that some fired in tests centuries ago were later found kilometers away and are displayed beside her. When she burst firing a birthday salute in 1681, an eyewitness suspected the English-made gunpowder charge — a Scottish gun could never fail on its own, obviously. She lay retired in the Tower of London for decades until Sir Walter Scott — the same writer who found the lost crown jewels — campaigned to bring her home. Edinburgh threw her a parade.

Inside the Great Hall

Not everything at the castle is about cannons and cliffs. Step into the Great Hall and look up, all the way up, at the ceiling. It’s made of enormous curved beams of dark oak, fitted together without a single nail, like the upside-down hull of a wooden ship. Builders finished it more than five hundred years ago for King James the Fourth, the same king who once dragged Mons Meg off to war. This was the castle’s grand party room, where kings held feasts, banquets, and important meetings, with roaring fires, roasted meat, music, and long tables packed with guests in their finest clothes.

Now look around the walls. They’re covered, absolutely bristling, with weapons and armor. There are long pikes taller than a grown man, swords, shields, and suits of shining metal armor arranged in patterns, as if the whole room is showing off its muscles. A full suit of that armor could weigh as much as you do, and knights had to be trained for years just to move and fight while wearing it. Imagine walking, let alone swinging a sword, dressed in a metal suit heavier than a big backpack full of bricks.

But here’s the best secret in the room, and you have to hunt for it. High up on one wall, near the fireplace,

there's a small hidden opening. It's called the laird's lug, which is an old Scots way of saying the lord's ear. The story goes that the king could sit in a little private room next door and listen in through that gap, secretly spying on the conversations of his guests in the hall below. So while everyone was chatting and feasting, thinking they were alone, the king might have been right there behind the wall, quietly hearing every word. Were they plotting against him? Were they being loyal? He wanted to know. See if you can spot the laird's lug from down on the floor. And next time you think you're having a private conversation, remember the kings of Scotland, and check the walls for secret ears.

The Memorial Full of Animals

At the very top of the castle, on the highest point of the rock, there's a special quiet building called the Scottish National War Memorial. It's a calm, hushed place, and it's here to remember all the Scottish soldiers who died in wars, a hundred years ago and since. Inside, there are long books that hold the name of every single one of them, and the books rest on a stone casket, and here's the astonishing part. That casket sits right on the bare, rocky top of the castle rock itself, the real stone poking straight up through the smooth marble floor. It's as if the ancient rock is holding the names in its own hands. When you go in, speak softly, and see if you can spot where the rough grey rock breaks through the shiny floor.

But here's the surprising thing I want you to look for, because most grown-ups miss it. This memorial doesn't only remember people. It remembers animals too. Carved into the walls, you can find all the creatures that helped in the wars and died alongside the soldiers. There are horses and mules that hauled heavy guns and carts through the mud. There are reindeer and even other beasts of burden. There are carrier pigeons, brave little birds who flew important messages back and forth over the battlefields when nothing else could get through.

And my favourites of all, hiding in the carvings, are the mice and the canaries. Why would tiny mice and little yellow birds be honoured on a war memorial? Because they were heroes in their own small way. Soldiers digging secret tunnels underground were in terrible danger from invisible poison gas that they couldn't see or smell. So they brought mice and canaries down with them. If the little animals suddenly got sick, the soldiers knew the air had turned deadly and it was time to get out, fast. Those tiny creatures saved human lives with their own. On the memorial they're called the tunnellers' friends, and there's a line carved there that asks everyone to remember the humble beasts that served and died.

So when you visit this peaceful room, look up and go hunting. Find the horses, find the pigeons, and see if you can spot the smallest heroes of all, the little mouse and the canary, carved forever into the walls of a castle, never to be forgotten.

The Hidden Crown and the Stolen Stone

Scotland's Crown Jewels — the Honours of Scotland — are older than England's, and they've spent a surprising amount of time buried. When Oliver Cromwell invaded in the 1650s, he'd already melted down England's crown jewels and came for Scotland's next. So Scots smuggled the crown, sword and scepter out of a besieged castle — one story says lowered down the castle wall and carried off hidden in a bundle — and buried them under the floor of a small country church for nine years. Cromwell never found them. Then, after Scotland and England joined parliaments in 1707, the Honours were locked in a chest in this castle and simply... forgotten. For over a hundred years. In 1818, the writer Sir Walter Scott got permission to break open the sealed room, and there they were, wrapped in linen, exactly where they'd been left. Next to them sits an ancient block of sandstone: the Stone of Destiny, on which Scottish kings were crowned for centuries — until an English king stole it in 1296 and put it under his throne in London, where it stayed for seven hundred years. In 1950, four Scottish students stole it BACK from Westminster Abbey on Christmas Day, accidentally breaking it in two, and hid it for months. England finally returned it officially in 1996. It still travels to London for coronations. It's a very well-traveled rock.

Related listening: England's Crown Jewels and Scotland's older Honours, each with its own famous heist story. Listen back — “The Crown Jewels: The World's Most Guarded Sparkle” (Tower of London, Day 3). Related listening: The Stone of Destiny sat under the Abbey's Coronation Chair for seven hundred years before returning to Scotland. Listen back — “The Church Where Kings Are Crowned” (Westminster Walk, Day 6).

Tell Me More: The Student Heist of 1950

The 1950 Stone of Destiny heist deserves the full story, because four students really did out-plan a kingdom. Ian Hamilton, a law student, and three friends drove from Glasgow to London in two small cars on Christmas Eve. Ian hid inside Westminster Abbey to unlock a door from within — a cleaner found him and, incredibly, just threw him out, assuming he was a tramp. So they broke in through a side door instead, at four in the morning. The Stone weighs a hundred and fifty two kilograms; as they hauled it from under the Coronation Chair, it slipped — breaking off a corner and, according to Ian, nearly crushing his toes. They loaded the big piece into one car, the broken corner into the other, and drove off — at one point a policeman knocked on the window while the Stone sat hidden under a coat on the back seat; the two students pretended to be a courting couple, chatted cheerfully with the officer, and drove away. Roadblocks went up across Britain; the border was watched for the first time in centuries. The students had guessed this — so they first drove SOUTH, hiding the Stone in a field in Kent for two weeks, then came back for it when the fuss died down. It was repaired by a sympathetic stonemason and finally left, wrapped in a Scottish flag, at Arbroath Abbey — where Scotland's independence was declared in 1320. Nobody went to jail; prosecuting them would have been too embarrassing, and too popular. Ian Hamilton became a respected lawyer and never regretted a thing.

The Baby Prince Born on the Rock

Here's something amazing about this castle. A real baby was born up here on the rock, and that baby grew up to become king of not one country but two. It happened on the nineteenth of June, in the year fifteen sixty-six. The baby's mother was one of the most famous people in all of Scottish history, Mary, Queen of Scots. Find the royal apartments and look for the tiny room where it happened. It's astonishingly small, barely bigger than a cupboard, with a low ceiling and one little window looking out over the whole city far below. Imagine, a future king came into the world in a room you could cross in three steps.

But this was not a happy, peaceful time, and the story has real danger in it. Mary's life was full of enemies and plots. Just three months before the baby was born, a gang of armed men had burst into her dinner and murdered her private secretary right in front of her, while she was heavily pregnant. People whispered that the shock might harm the baby. And Mary's own husband, the baby's father, was jealous and cruel, and he even spread a horrible rumor that the child wasn't really his son. Mary was so upset and so determined to prove him wrong that, the story goes, she held the newborn baby up and swore in front of witnesses that this was the king's true son and no one else's.

That little baby was named James. And what a life he had ahead of him. When he was just thirteen months old, younger than almost any baby you know, his mother was forced off her throne, and tiny James was crowned King of Scotland while he was still a toddler who couldn't even walk properly. He never saw his mother again after he was a baby. But the truly astonishing part comes later. Many years on, when the Queen of England died with no children of her own, they looked around for who should be the next ruler, and the answer was James, the baby born in this little castle room. So he became King James the Sixth of Scotland and King James the First of England, at the very same time, ruling both countries at once. All of that, beginning in a room up here no bigger than a closet.

Where the Stone Is Now

Now here's a twist you need to know before you go looking. When you stand in the Crown Room and see the shining crown, the sword, and the scepter, you might expect the famous Stone of Destiny to be sitting right there beside them, the way it was for many years. But it isn't there anymore. The old grey block of sandstone has moved house. Just two years ago, in the spring of twenty twenty-four, the Stone of Destiny left Edinburgh Castle and travelled to a brand-new museum in a town called Perth, about an hour north of here. So if you were hoping to see it today at the castle, that's the puzzle. It has gone.

Why did it move? Well, the Stone actually belongs, deep in history, to that part of Scotland. Long, long ago, before it was ever stolen away to London, Scottish kings were crowned sitting on this stone at a place called Scone, which is right next to Perth. So after seven hundred years of the Stone being carried off, first to England and then to this castle, people decided it should finally go back home to the region it came from. They built it a special new room in the Perth Museum, and enormous crowds came to see it when the museum opened. It was the first time in more than seven centuries that the Stone had returned to its true home ground.

Don't feel too sad about missing it, though, because there's still plenty of magic in that Crown Room without it. And here's the thing to remember about this well-travelled rock. Even now, even in its new home in Perth, the Stone isn't allowed to just sit still and rest. When a new king or queen is crowned, the Stone still has to make the long journey all the way south to London, so the new monarch can be crowned above it, just as monarchs have been for centuries. The very last time that happened was in twenty twenty-three, when King Charles was crowned, and the Stone travelled down for the ceremony and then came straight back to Scotland afterward. So this ancient block of sandstone, older than the castle itself, is still going on adventures. It just does it from Perth now.

The Scariest Dinner in the Castle

I'm going to tell you a true story that is a little bit scary, so get ready. It's about a dinner that went horribly wrong, right here in this castle, almost six hundred years ago, and it's so dramatic that a famous writer used it in one of the most shocking scenes on television. But this one really happened.

Long ago, in the year fourteen forty, Scotland had a king who was only ten years old, just a boy, named James the Second. Because he was so young, grown-up men around him did the real ruling, and those men were greedy and worried. What worried them most was a mighty family called the Douglasses, who were so rich and had so many soldiers that they were almost as powerful as the king himself. The head of the Douglas family was a teenager, sixteen years old, and he had a little brother too. The men running the country decided these Douglas boys were too dangerous to leave alone.

So they came up with a wicked plan. They invited the two Douglas brothers to the castle for a grand friendly dinner with the boy king. Now, back then, inviting someone to eat at your table was a sacred promise. It meant, you are my guest, you are completely safe with me. The Douglas boys trusted that promise. They came, they sat down, and the four young people, the two brothers and the little king, ate and laughed together, having a lovely time.

And then it happened. The story says a servant carried in a covered dish and set it on the table in front of the older Douglas boy. When it was uncovered, it wasn't food at all. It was the head of a big black bull. In those days, a black bull's head meant one terrible thing. It meant death. It was a signal. Suddenly guards seized the two brothers. The little ten-year-old king cried and begged the men to stop, because he liked the Douglas boys and knew it was wrong to hurt his own guests. But nobody listened to a child, even a king. The two brothers were taken outside and never came back.

It was a cruel trick, a way for powerful men to get rid of a family they feared, all disguised as a friendly meal. And here's the modern twist. The writer who created Game of Thrones has said this very dinner gave him the idea for one of the most famous, most shocking scenes in the whole story. So the next time you sit down to a nice safe dinner with your family, you can tell them the tale of the black bull's head, served at Edinburgh Castle, in a room you can still walk into today. Just maybe wait until after pudding.

Your Castle Treasure Hunt

Ready for a challenge? This castle is enormous, and it's stuffed with hidden things that most visitors rush straight past. So here is your secret mission. As you explore, try to hunt down every single one of these treasures. Count them off, and see how many your family can find before you leave. Some are easy. Some are really sneaky.

Treasure number one, right at the entrance, two stone heroes guarding the gate. One is William Wallace and one is Robert the Bruce, Scotland's two most famous warriors. Can you work out which is which?

Treasure number two, the tiniest building on the whole rock. It only fits about twenty people, and it's the oldest building in the entire city. Find the little chapel and stand inside the oldest room in Edinburgh.

Treasure number three, a giant's cannon. Find Mons Meg, the monster gun, and look right into her enormous mouth. It's wide enough to fit your whole head. Then find the gigantic stone cannonballs beside her, each one heavier than a grown-up.

Treasure number four, a secret ear. Go into the Great Hall, look high up on the wall near the fireplace, and find the little hidden opening called the laird's lug, where a king could secretly listen in on people's conversations. Whisper a secret and see if anyone's listening.

Treasure number five, the good dogs. Find the tiny dog graveyard and count the little headstones of all the brave soldier dogs buried up here.

Treasure number six, and this is a hard one, a hidden doorway. Somewhere there's a low door that leads down into a buried tower, the secret rooms that survived the great siege hundreds of years ago. Ask a guard if you get stuck.

Treasure number seven, the rock through the floor. In the quiet war memorial at the very top, find the place where the ancient grey rock of the castle pokes right up through the smooth marble floor.

Treasure number eight, a homesick sailor's flag. Down in the old prison, find the wooden door with the American flag scratched into it by a prisoner all those years ago.

And treasure number nine, if you time it right, the biggest bang of all. Be ready near one o'clock, cover your ears, and wait for the One O'Clock Gun. Then watch to see who jumps.

Find all nine, and you're an official castle explorer. Good luck, and keep your eyes open. The best treasures are the ones nobody else notices.